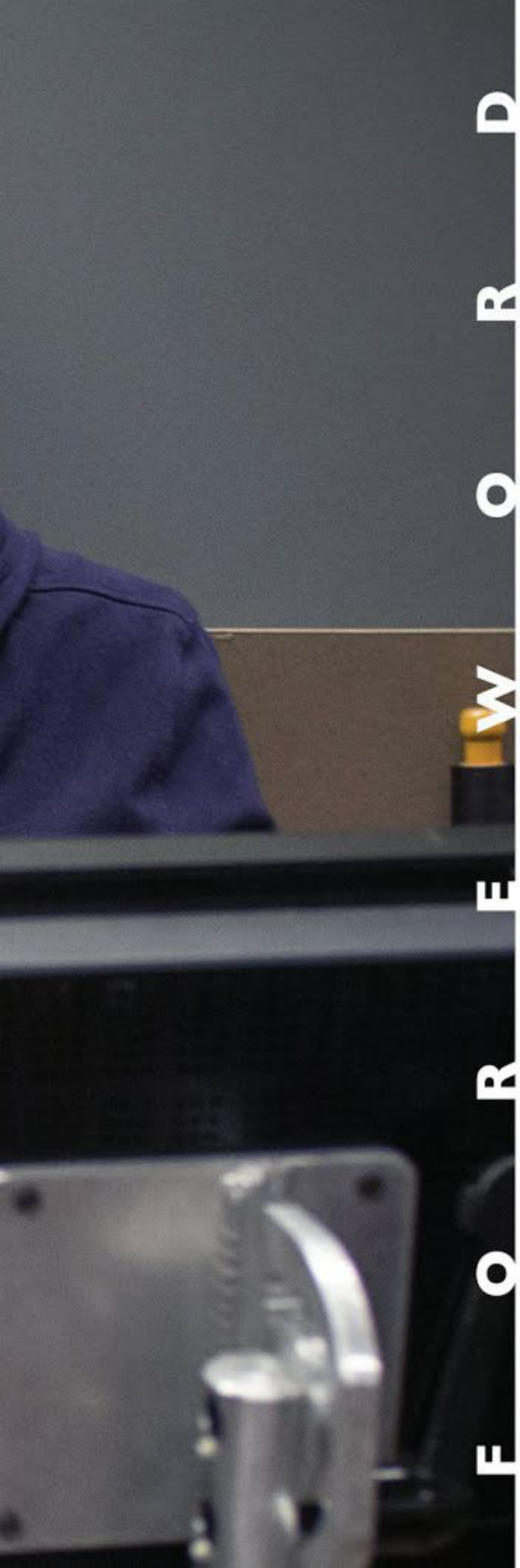



*"I love comedies, musicals, and thrillers like everybody else, but I confess to believing action pictures are what movies are essentially about."*
–Walter Hill

*"Action: the fact or process of doing something, typically to achieve aim."*
–Noah Webster

It was in the late '70s, sitting in front of a Zenith television in the living room of the duplex we were raised in, that we watched The *French Connection* for the first time. It was on the late show. Maybe it was a Saturday night. Our father enjoyed movies as a way to decompress from the work week. He had a high motor and was a bit of an insomniac–two conditions we inherited from him–so he loved the late show as a way to occupy his restless night hours. Most weekends, he'd let us stay up to watch movies with him–so that he could share his love of cinema with us, and so that he had some company to laugh with him at the Bowery Boys. Or root for Bogart. Or be amused and vaguely frightened at any number of Hammer films.

But it was our viewing of *The French Connection* that evening that had a lasting impact on us. The emotions we felt when we watched it. The visceral intensity. Both filmmakers and audiences are well aware of the brilliance of the car chase in that film. But Friedkin made a walking foot chase equally as exciting to us. Our young minds had never seen action so expertly executed. The camera work. The emotional commitment of the actors. The sound design. The juxtaposition of images. The escalation of stakes. Thirty-five years later, there are moments we can still recall from our first viewing of that film. That's impactful filmmaking.

The definition of action films may have been slightly misappropriated by splashy, expensive movies from the late '80s. All movies expertly made, and movies we loved–*Die Hard*, *Predator, First Blood*–but the term has a more universal meaning than the narrow genre application it's fallen into. As Webster points out, action is "the fact or process of doing something, typically to achieve aim." The most significant part of the definition for our process as filmmakers–and what we learned from Friedkin that night in our living room–is that, as stated, action has the typical intent of achieving aim. For us, aim is a goal. Aim is storytelling. Aim is narrative.

In all of our favorite action sequences, the character has an emotional aim. Personal stakes. The aim can be selfish or vaguely corrupt, as it is in *The French Connection*, but it's an aim nonetheless. And that aim is the engine of the action. It's the engine of every beat of the action. Each beat in a great action sequence is an inventive, detailed, harrowing, and thoughtful mini-narrative about whether the character will achieve their said aim by the end of the sequence–and, ultimately, by the end of the film.

In *The French Connection*'s car chase, Popeye Doyle wants to capture a hitman who just tried to kill him. The aim on a plot level is clear and simple. Yet on a narrative level, it's much more complex: Doyle is a restless, overzealous cop who is greatly disliked by a federal agent named Mulderig, who blames Doyle's recklessness for the death of a fellow policeman. In capturing this hitman–and seizing a massive shipment of heroin heading for New York City–Doyle has the unspoken aim of vindicating himself as a great cop whose current achievement will outshine his marred history. What made the car chase so groundbreaking was Doyle's desperate commitment to his aim. This desperation was infused into every microfiber of every action beat in the movie. And that's what made it such a seminal film.

It was in 1982 that we saw *Blow Out* for the first time. On a VHS tape rented from a small video